

Georgia Tech - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Above-average Power Four / fringe top-40 baseline with upside if the new offensive spine settles quickly.
Preseason consensus	AP Others receiving votes (4 points) · Conference poll ACC No. 5 (2,006 points; 2 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 42
Returning production	49% (No. 85) overall · Off. 37% (No. 119) · Def. 61% (No. 28)
Primer power rating	+6.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.1 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Likely worse overall because the elite offensive efficiency/continuity base is being rebuilt; defensive improvement is possible but not proven.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Georgia Tech shifts to OC George Godsey's run-supported offense around expected QB Alberto Mendoza, RB Justice Haynes and a deep RB/TE group, while new DC Jason Semore tries to create more disruption.

Bottom line: Backfield talent, defensive returning production and special teams keep Tech competitive, but QB/WR/OL turnover and a low-havoc defense make six wins the safer baseline.

Beats expectations if: Mendoza processes Godsey's protection/terminology burden efficiently, Haynes and Hosley keep the offense ahead of the sticks, the reconfigured line survives Petty's uncertainty, and Semore turns a veteran linebacker core plus transfer front/secondary pieces into more disruption than the 2025 defense produced.

Disappoints if: The offense cannot replace King/Rivers/Rutherford and veteran OL continuity quickly enough, forcing an unproven quarterback into obvious passing downs while the rebuilt defense remains average in efficiency and weak at creating havoc.

Five things to remember

- 1 Quarterback:** Alberto Mendoza is the expected starting quarterback, but he replaces three-year centerpiece Haynes King and enters with limited prior college passing volume.
- 2 Offensive line:** Georgia Tech returns only 37% of offensive production (No. 119), including major losses at quarterback, wide receiver and offensive line.
- 3 2025 baseline:** Justice Haynes leads a deep backfield, with Malachi Hosley returning after 697 rushing yards and seven touchdowns in 2025.
- 4 Coaching:** Both coordinator jobs changed: George Godsey is the offensive play-caller, while Jason Semore takes over a defense that ranked No. 117 in havoc created in 2025.
- 5 Offensive line:** OT Josh Petty had not been cleared as of Aug. 12, and the final OL five plus receiver and secondary hierarchies remained unsettled.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (6-2 ACC)	● Good
Scoring	32.2 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	460.0 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	197.5 YPG · 5.5 YPC	● Very good
Pass efficiency	8.66 YPA · 16 TD / 7 INT	● Very good
Third downs	46.1%	● Very good
Scoring defense	25.0 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	399.2 YPG allowed	● Below average
Rush defense	164.0 YPG · 4.6 YPC	● Below average
Pass defense	235.2 YPG · 7.49 YPA · 19 TD allowed	● Below average

Georgia Tech’s offense was a clear top-30 strength; the defense was below average by yardage and efficiency.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.52 · No. 28	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.111 · No. 26	● Very good
Off. success rate	50.1% · No. 9	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	14.5% · No. 18	● Very good
Havoc allowed	11.0% · No. 7	● Elite
Opp.-adjusted defense	-0.08 · No. 68	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.045 · No. 85	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	42.8% · No. 83	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.4% · No. 79	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	12.9% · No. 117	● Poor

Advanced-stat read: The offense was high-end in success rate, explosiveness, EPA and havoc avoidance. The defense was average-to-poor and created little havoc.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Brent Key - returning	● ↔ Keeps the program’s physical identity and leadership structure stable entering 2026.
OC / play-caller	◆ George Godsey - new external coordinator	● ↓ Major scheme transition despite clear play-calling responsibility
DC/LB	◆ Jason Semore - new external coordinator	● ↔ New coordinator tasked with improving disruption

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Alberto Mendoza	Indiana	● ↔ Expected starter and the central succession piece after Haynes King; role certainty is high.
◆ RB Justice Haynes	Michigan	● ↑ Leads the room and carries Doak Walker/Maxwell recognition, giving Tech a high-end replacement option after Jamal Haynes departs.
◆ C Joseph Ionata	Alabama	● ↔ Projected starting center and a key stabilizer in a line replacing multiple veteran contributors.
◆ WR Isaiah Fuhrmann	Elon	● ↔ Anticipated major receiver in a room replacing Eric Rivers, Malik Rutherford and transfer-out Isiah Canion.

Out	To	Loss
QB Haynes King	NFL (Carolina), undrafted free agent	● ↓ ACC Player of the Year and offensive centerpiece departs.
WR Eric Rivers	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ One of the two leading pass-catchers departs.
WR Malik Rutherford	Atlanta Falcons rookie path	● ↓ Another leading pass-catcher departs.
OL Keylan Rutledge	NFL (Houston), Round 1, No. 26	● ↓ First-round pick is a major line loss.
RB Jamal Haynes	NFL (Cincinnati), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Major veteran back departs.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Clear step back in proven continuity, partially offset by a talented new backfield and targeted transfer replacements.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ CB Jaylen Mbakwe	Alabama	● ↑ The current projection gives significant snap share; his athletic ceiling gives a rebuilt secondary a potentially high-impact addition.
◆ DE Noah Carter	Alabama	● ↔ Projected major front role in a unit replacing drafted interior production and trying to improve a poor 2025 havoc-creation profile.
◆ DE Jordan Walker	Rutgers	● ↔ Expected major edge role and part of the broad front rebuild; exact production level remains projection-heavy.
◆ DT Tawfiq Thomas	Colorado	● ↔ Likely major interior role after Jordan van den Berg's departure.

Out	To	Loss
DT Jordan van den Berg	NFL (Chicago), Round 6, No. 213	● ↓ The 2025 interior leader among Tech defensive linemen (44 tackles, three sacks) was drafted by Chicago.
DB Ahmari Harvey	NFL (Denver), undrafted free agent	● ↓ A 2025 starting defensive back leaves for an NFL opportunity with Denver, adding to secondary turnover.
LB Tah'j Butler	Ole Miss	● ↓ A 34-tackle, three-TFL 2025 linebacker transferred to Ole Miss, thinning the proven layer around Kyle Efford.
DB Clayton Powell-Lee	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Final-year secondary contributor departs.

Defensive net: ● ↔ More returning aggregate production than the offense, but still a high-variance rebuild across the line and secondary.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Personnel-flexible, run-supported OC George Godsey attack tailored to QB Alberto Mendoza.	Deep backfield and a 2025 template strong in efficiency/explosiveness.	QB, top pass-catchers and major OL pieces are gone.
Defense	DC Jason Semore emphasizes takeaways around LB Kyle Efford and a refreshed front/secondary.	61% defensive returning production plus credible back-end playmakers.	Average 2025 efficiency and No. 117 havoc creation.
Special teams	Potential team strength centered on proven kicker Aidan Birr, with a punter transition behind him.	SP+ ranks special teams No. 11 and Birr is first-team preseason All-ACC with Lou Groza recognition.	Punter Alex Bacchetta is an incoming candidate rather than a long-settled incumbent.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↓	Medium	QB Alberto Mendoza is expected to start but replaces QB Haynes King with limited volume.
RB	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Justice Haynes and RB Malachi Hosley form a strong two-back core.
WR	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Rivers and Rutherford leave for professional football and Canion transfers to Georgia.
TE	● B-	● ↔	Medium	Corbo carries Mackey recognition and Harris brought 531 prior receiving yards.
OL	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	Carney and projected C Ionata are credible anchors.
DL/Edge	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	Transfers replenish a front that loses DT Jordan van den Berg and lacked havoc.
LB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	Kyle Efford is the established anchor and Lightsey is a major-role candidate, though Tah’j Butler transfers out.
Secondary	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	Mbakwe and Riley provide encouraging current role outlook.
Special teams	● A-	● ↔	Medium-high	SP+ No. 11 and K Aidan Birr are strengths; punter is the transition.
Coaching	● B-	● ↓	Medium	Brent Key and Weinke provide continuity, but both coordinator roles changed.
Overall	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	The +6.0/No. 42 SP+ baseline fits an above-average Power Four roster with backfield strength but major QB/WR/OL and coordinator transition.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Alberto Mendoza (TR: Indiana)	QB	● Expected Power Four starter / high-variance transition point	-	His adaptation determines whether the offense can preserve the efficiency of the King era.
◆ Justice Haynes (TR: Michigan)	RB	● High-end Power Four starter projection	Doak Walker · Maxwell	Leads the backfield and is the most important incoming skill player in the offensive reset.
Malachi Hosley	RB	● High-end complementary back	Doak Walker	Already produced 697 rushing yards and seven TD in 2025 and gives Tech a second credible lead-caliber option.
Kyle Efford	LB	● High-end conference starter	Butkus	Returning linebacker anchor for a defense trying to become more disruptive under Semore.
◆ Jaylen Mbakwe (TR: Alabama)	CB	● High-upside projected starter	-	Current outlook projects significant snap share after his move back to corner in a rebuilt secondary.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Malachi Carney	OL	● Established line anchor	Outland	His move from tackle to guard and experience are central to stabilizing a line with major departures and an unresolved Petty timeline.
Aidan Birr	K	● National-level specialist / conference first-team selection	ACC 1st team · Lou Groza	The clearest proven advantage on a special-teams unit ranked No. 11 by SP+.
◆ Chris Corbo (TR: Dartmouth)	TE	● Projected major Power Four role	John Mackey	A central piece of the multi-TE structure and one of the few pass-game additions with preseason recognition.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Above-average difficulty for a transition-heavy team: manageable ACC swing games are mixed with home Tennessee and road trips to Clemson and Georgia.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Difficult · SP+ SOS No. 38
Hardest stretch	Louisville -> at Clemson -> Wake Forest -> at Georgia
Swing games	Duke, at Virginia Tech, at Pittsburgh, Louisville, Wake Forest
Advantage	The lone bye follows the Stanford trip and precedes the main ACC run, and seven home games include several of the more manageable conference opponents.
Expected	6.1 wins · most likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 9-4 record and ACC No. 5 poll placement can create a stronger reputation than a No. 42 SP+ baseline supports.
Back them when	When the matchup lets Haynes/Hosley and the multiple-TE run structure protect Mendoza from obvious passing downs, especially against opponents that do not force the rebuilt receiver/OL groups to win one-on-one for four quarters.
Fade/pass when	Against strong passing/pressure teams or when Tech is priced off last year’s offensive efficiency before the new quarterback, receiver hierarchy and line prove they can sustain it.
Key monitor	Josh Petty clearance/opening availability, final OL five, starting receiver hierarchy, secondary alignment, Mendoza early command of protections/terminology, Semore front disruption/turnover creation
Week 1 baseline	Georgia Tech -7.5 vs. Colorado · rating-only baseline; Georgia Tech primer +6.0 minus Colorado primer +0.5 plus 2.0 default home field; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Georgia Tech –6.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Georgia Tech’s transition is concentrated on offense: QB Alberto Mendoza replaces QB Haynes King, while RB Justice Haynes/RB Malachi Hosley give OC George Godsey a strong backfield to protect the new passing game. WR and OL turnover make last year’s elite efficiency difficult to assume.

DC Jason Semore inherits useful defensive continuity but also a unit that created little havoc, while special teams remains a strength. **6.1 wins and 6-6** is the baseline for a dangerous but transition-heavy ACC team; 2026 is more a test of whether the program’s identity survives the King/Faulkner turnover than a simple continuation of 2025.

About this primer

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